

## Chapter 7: The Choice That Broke Them

That day felt different.

Not soft.

Not peaceful.

Heavy.

Like the world itself knew something was about to end.

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Luna stepped through the door slowly this time.

Not running.

Not smiling immediately.

Just... looking at him.

Kyros was already there.

But he didn't move.

Didn't come closer like always.

Because he saw it.

The hesitation in her eyes.

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"You're quiet," he said softly.

She forced a small smile.

"Just tired."

He didn't believe it.

But he didn't push.

“Come,” he said, offering his hand.

She looked at it.

For a moment too long.

Then held it.

But not as tightly as before.

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They walked.

Same path.

Same place.

Same sky.

But nothing felt the same.

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“Kyros...” she called softly.

“Hm?”

“If I stop coming... what will you do?”

His steps slowed.

But he didn't stop.

“I'll wait.”

Same answer.

Same calm voice.

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This time—

It hurt her.

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“Don’t,” she whispered.

He looked at her.

“Why?”

“Because...” her voice broke slightly, “...you deserve more than waiting for someone who might not come back.”

Silence.

---

Kyros stopped walking.

So she had to stop too.

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“Look at me,” he said quietly.

She didn’t want to.

But she did.

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“Did something happen?” he asked.

She shook her head.

But her eyes said everything.

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“My health...” she started slowly.

His expression changed instantly.

“What about it?”

She looked down at their joined hands.

“I don’t feel okay anymore... even outside.”

His grip tightened.

“What do you mean?”

“My body feels weak... my head hurts... sometimes I can’t even breathe properly.”

Each word felt heavier than the last.

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Kyros’s jaw tightened.

“...Since when?”

She didn’t answer.

Because he already knew.

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“Since you started coming here more,” he finished softly.

Her silence confirmed it.

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“No,” he said immediately.

“Kyros—”

“No,” he repeated, shaking his head.

“This place isn’t hurting you.”

Her eyes filled with tears.

“Then why does it feel like it is?”

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That question—

He couldn't answer.

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Silence fell.

Heavy.

Painful.

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"I think..." her voice trembled, "...I think I shouldn't come here anymore."

---

Everything stopped.

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Kyros looked at her like he didn't understand the words.

Like he refused to.

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“No.”

It came out instantly.

Firm.

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“I'm serious,” she whispered.

“And I'm not accepting it.”

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She stepped closer.

Tears falling now.

“Kyros... please understand.”

“I do understand,” he said, his voice breaking slightly.

“That you’re scared.”

“I \*am\* scared!” she cried softly.

“I’m scared of losing myself... of not waking up... of—”

Her voice cracked completely.

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He pulled her into him.

Tightly.

More tightly than ever before.

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“Then don’t go,” he whispered against her hair.

“Stay.”

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Her heart shattered.

Because for a second—

She wanted to.

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“I can’t...” she cried softly.

“I can’t lose my real life.”

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He froze.

That word.

\*Real.\*

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“So this isn’t real?” he asked quietly.

She pulled back, panicking.

“That’s not what I meant—”

“Then what did you mean?”

His eyes—

They weren’t soft anymore.

They were hurt.

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“You’re real,” she said quickly.

“This... us... it’s real to me.”

“\*To you\*,” he repeated.

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Tears streamed down her face.

“I don’t know how to explain it...”

“Then don’t,” he said softly.

Because maybe—

He didn’t want to hear it.

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“I don’t want to leave you,” she whispered.

“Then don’t.”

---

Silence.

Again.

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Her hands slowly held his.

Tighter this time.

Like she was memorizing him.

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“But I have to,” she said.

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That broke him.

Completely.

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Kyros didn't speak.

Didn't argue.

Didn't stop her.

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He just stood there.

Looking at her.

Like he was trying to remember every detail.

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“When did you decide this?” he asked quietly.

“Today.”

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A small, broken smile appeared on his face.

“So fast...”

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“I thought about it the whole day,” she whispered.

“And if I come back again... I won’t be able to leave.”

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He nodded slowly.

Like he understood.

Even if it hurt.

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“I don’t want to become someone who escapes reality,” she said.

“I don’t want to lose myself... even if it means losing you.”

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That line—

Was the final one.

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The golden light slowly appeared.

The door.

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Neither of them looked at it immediately.

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“Say something...” she whispered.

Her voice small.

Fragile.

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Kyros stepped closer.

One last time.

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His hand gently cupped her face.

Just like before.

But this time—

It trembled slightly.

---

“You were never something I wanted to lose,” he said softly.

Her tears fell faster.

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“Then hate me,” she whispered.

“It’ll be easier.”

---

He shook his head.

“I don’t know how to do that... not with you.”

---

Her heart broke completely.

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“I love you,” she said.

Not softly.

Not hesitantly.

But like it was the last time.

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He closed his eyes for a second.

Then opened them.

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“I know,” he whispered.

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She waited.

For him to say it back.

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But he didn't.

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Not because he didn't feel it.

But because if he said it—

He wouldn't let her go.

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That silence hurt more than words.

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She stepped back slowly.

Her hands slipping from his.

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“Take care...” she whispered.

---

Kyros didn’t move.

Didn’t stop her.

---

Because he knew—

If he tried...

She would still leave.

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She turned.

Walked toward the door.

Each step heavier than the last.

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Just before stepping through—

She stopped.

But she didn't turn back.

Because if she did—

She wouldn't go.

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“...Don’t wait for me,” she whispered.

---

Silence behind her.

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And then—

She stepped through.

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Luna woke up.

Her room.

Her world.

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Her chest felt heavy.

But her breathing—

Was clearer.

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Tears slipped quietly down her temples.

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Because somewhere—

In a world she chose to leave behind—

Someone she loved...

Was still standing.

Exactly where she left him.

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Waiting.

Even after she told him not to.